

The function of performance appraisal in UK universities

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Abstract. This study mapped the development of performance appraisal in UK universities and assessed the initial impact of appraisal in four case study institutions. University staff felt that appraisal has had little impact on their motivation, efficiency and performance. One reason for this may be the ambiguity surrounding the intentions of staff appraisal in universities: it is neither a management tool, nor is it wholly focused on staff development. If appraisal is primarily concerned with assessment, it must be linked to promotion and merit pay awards. The current arrangement of using agreed summaries from the appraisal interviews in promotion procedures is not entirely satisfactory and requires further consideration. If, on the other hand, appraisal is intended for the purposes of staff development, this aim should be explicitly stated and backed up with adequate resources and effective procedures designed to ensure that identified training needs are met.

While universities have responded to the need to develop appraisal schemes there is very little sense in which appraisal has been given a coherent function in relation to other aspects of management. If appraisal is to promote change in universities, it must be incorporated in university and departmental planning.

Introduction

In recent years universities have had to respond to the need for greater accountability and efficiency in their use of public resources (Buss 1975; Clarke and Birt 1982; Shattock 1982; Sizer 1987). The Jarratt Report (1985) outlined the need for universities to increase their efficiency and accountability. To meet these challenges, Jarratt felt that universities must adopt a more systematic, managerial style of governance. The report promoted the introduction of a range of measures to monitor the performance of individuals, departments and institutions. Systematic staff appraisal has recently been introduced in universities. Its introduction was a condition of the 1987 salary settlement (the 23rd Report).

Between 1989–90 the present authors examined academic opinion regarding the introduction of staff appraisal in two universities prior to the implementation of appraisal schemes. The results of this study (Haslam *et al.* 1992) indicated that staff were in favour of appraisal where they believed the emphasis of the scheme was on individual staff development. They expected staff appraisal to benefit them in terms of clarifying expectations and providing useful feedback. Additionally, they felt that systematic appraisal may result in greater accountability, improved motivation through the recognition of good performance and the identification of training needs. However, some thought that the appraisal process would be very time consuming and costly to administer and that it could have adverse effects on staff morale if the identified training needs are not met. Many noted that the appraisal process is not backed up by sufficient opportunities for career advancement and

were therefore sceptical about its potential for greater efficiency and improved staff performance.

This article reports findings from the post-appraisal phase of the research which examined the actual response of university staff and senior managers to the implementation of performance appraisal in universities.

Methodology

The study involved a national telephone survey of all universities and university colleges and four in-depth case studies in selected universities. Telephone interviews were conducted with Personnel Officers or Staff Training and Development Officers to ascertain the timescales for appraisal implementation, attitudes and planned approaches.

Using questionnaires and interviews with appraisers, appraisees and senior managers, the case studies were designed to establish the aims and objectives of the schemes and examine the impact of the appraisal process. The principal research instruments, a self-completion postal questionnaire and semi-structured interview schedules¹, were piloted at Loughborough University, though the results of this pilot study are not included in this article.

In two of the four universities, surveys and interviews were carried out both *before* and *after* the first round of appraisal. In the other two universities (where appraisal had been underway for some time) surveys and interviews were conducted after at least one round of appraisal interviews had taken place, hence in these case studies, post-appraisal views only were sought.

The pre-appraisal findings are reported elsewhere (Haslam *et al.* 1992). This paper reports findings from the post-appraisal phase of the research which comprises surveys and interviews conducted in the four case study institutions (the two universities selected for the 'before' and 'after' study and the two selected for post-appraisal views only).

In each institution two academic-related and eight academic departments were targeted. Comparable departments were chosen across the four case study universities. Letters were sent to Heads of Departments asking if they would be willing for their department to participate in the study. If they refused, further departments in the same faculty were approached. If an affirmative response was obtained questionnaires were sent to staff in the departments. Approximately six to eight weeks later reminder letters and questionnaires were sent out to all non-respondents.

The questionnaires allowed us to gauge both general responses to appraisal and views about specific features of the schemes. The interviews allowed detailed probing of the respondents' feelings about appraisal which were not accessible to the questionnaire approach. To avoid an obvious bias, the interview sample comprised both respondents and non-respondents from the postal survey.

Interviewees were chosen to reflect the range of career levels and, where possible, the Heads of each department were interviewed. The senior managers of the four universities including Vice Chancellors, Pro-Vice Chancellors and

Table 1. Stage of implementation in academic year 1989–90 – all staff (academic and academic-related)

Stage	England, Scotland and Northern Ireland	Wales	London
Pilot scheme	6	2	2
1st round	19	2	7
2nd round	6	1	1
3rd round	4	–	–
4th round	–	–	–
5th round	1	–	–
Other*	9	1	17
Total	45	6	27

*Other 'A' – Academic staff
'A-R' – Academic-related staff

	E, S & N.I.	W.	L.
(i) 1st round 'A' only	1	1	
(ii) 1st round 'A' and "some" 'A-R'	1		
(iii) 1st 50% 'A' and 1st 50% 'A-R'	2		
(iv) 1st 50% 'A' and 2nd 50% 'A-R'	1		
(v) 1st 20% 'A' and 1st round 'A-R'	1		
(vi) 2nd round 'A' and 1st round 'A-R'	1		
(vii) 3rd round 'A' only	1		
(viii) 3rd round 'A' and senior 'A-R' 1st round 'A-R' and researchers	1		
(xi) 1st round 'A' cont. and fallow for 'A-R'			1
(x) Fallow year in biennial cycle 'A' and 'A-R'			1
(xi) Fallow year 'A' and 5th round 'A-R'			1
(xii) No timetable yet			2
(xiii) Not known			12
Total	9	1	17

Registrars were also interviewed, along with some lay members of council and local Association of University Teachers (AUT) representatives. The aim of the interviews was to explore, in more detail, the responses of university staff to the actual implementation of appraisal. The interviews were tape recorded and subsequently transcribed. The transcripts were subjected to qualitative analysis based on the sorting of emergent themes.

Results

Appraisal implementation

There was wide variation in appraisal implementation at the start of the research. In the academic year 1989/90 one university was conducting its fifth successive round

Table 2. Stage of implementation in Aug/Sept 1991 – all staff (academic and academic-related)

Stage (currently conducting)	England, Scotland and Northern Ireland	Wales
Pilot scheme	1	
1st round	3	2
2nd round	20	1
3rd round	9	1
4th round	3	
5th round		
6th round		
7th round	1	
1st fallow year of biennial scheme	5	1
Other*	3	1
Total	45	6
*Other 'A' – Academic staff		
'A-R' – Academic-related staff		
	E, S & N.I.	W.
(i) 1st round 'A' only	1	1
(ii) No timetable yet	1	
(iii) Not known	1	
Total	3	1

of appraisal, while at the other extreme a number of universities had yet to conduct pilot schemes or fix a timetable for the introduction of appraisal. Table 1 shows the national position in the academic year 1989/90.

At the end of the research a second telephone survey was conducted to obtain an update of the progress of appraisal in universities. Table 2 shows the national position (excluding London colleges) in August/September 1991.

The majority of universities had reached the stage of at least their second round of appraisal interviews.

The nature of the case study appraisal schemes

Two of the four case study universities were working on an annual cycle of appraisal interviews, but one had delayed the second round of appraisal interviews for over 18 months. The third university had opted for a biennial scheme. The fourth had not conducted one full round of appraisal interviews. This latter institution introduced appraisal in the first instance as a phased, voluntary scheme. It was voluntary on two levels because initially some departments had opted out of what was considered to be a 'dummy run.' Of those departments that were participating, after the Head of the Department had received training he or she invited volunteers from their department to be appraised. Typically one or two individuals in a department volunteered to be appraised.

In each of the institutions, Heads of Departments are responsible for allocating appraisers to appraisees. Each university has followed the guidelines agreed by the Committee of Vice Chancellors and Principals (CVCP) and the Association of University Teachers (AUT) in allowing the appraisee to request an alternative appraiser to the one designated to them. As regards the appraisal record itself, at one university the record is expunged if agreement is not achieved and a new agreed summary arrived at. In the other three universities, the appraisee can add a note of reservation to the appraisal documents. The position of all four institutions was that the appraisal record is confidential to the appraisee, appraiser and Head of Department (if the appraiser is not the Head of Department). Appraisal records are kept in separate files within the department.

All four institutions stressed in their appraisal documents the separation between appraisal and disciplinary procedures. As regards links with promotion, two universities had the arrangement whereby agreed summaries from the appraisal interview can be part of the material which a member of staff submits to a promotions board. Another university had abandoned this arrangement, for reasons described later. The fourth institution, which had delayed implementing appraisal, had not developed any arrangements for using agreed summaries.

While all the appraisal forms have a section for appraisers and appraisees to list a series of agreed action points, there are no formal arrangements to ensure that these are followed up. With regard to the notification of training needs, three of the institutions relied on Heads of Departments making a report to Staff Training and Development Units with respect to the training needs identified in their departments as a result of the appraisal interviews. At the other institution, the appraisal documentation consisted of a separate sheet for listing training needs which was sent directly to Staff Training and Development personnel.

Results from the postal survey

Two hundred and seventy-seven questionnaires were completed and returned. Table 3 shows the distribution of returned questionnaires and the overall response rates for each institution. The overall response rates were slightly disappointing, but comments we received from respondents suggested that many were overwhelmed

Table 3. Number of returns and response rates

	Returns	Response rate
University A	2*	—
University B	78	49%
University C	119	51%
University D	75	57%
Total (3 missing cases)	274	

*At the time of the fieldwork this institution was still in the pilot stage of implementation where appraisal was introduced as a phased, voluntary scheme.

Table 4. The survey sample breakdown by faculty

Faculty	Frequency
Academic related	55
Arts and Humanities	69
Engineering	34
Science	76
Social Science	41
Total (2 missing cases)	275

by paperwork associated with the many changes being implemented in universities and many were also largely uninterested in appraisal.

Table 4 gives a breakdown of the survey sample by faculty.

Table 5 shows the range of positions held within the universities by the respondents.

Of these respondents, 26% were designated appraisers (in addition to being appraisees), and 6% were actually involved in devising the appraisal schemes.

Staff were asked about the ways in which appraisal may have been of benefit to them personally. Around half of the sample disagreed with the notion that appraisal was useful in clarifying what is expected of them (the remaining half comprised 'don't know' and 'agree'). Fifty-eight percent did not believe that appraisal helped identify obstacles to their career development and 70% felt it did not provide the facilities to remove such obstacles. Two thirds felt that appraisal had not improved procedures for considering promotion. Half of the respondents had not found appraisal helpful in clarifying their own aims and objectives or those of their department. Sixty percent stated that appraisal had not improved their own motivation and 57% felt that it had not improved their performance.

Table 5. The survey sample breakdown by position held in the university

Position	Frequency
Head of department	4
Professor	28
Reader	23
Senior Lecturer	60
Lecturer	77
Researcher	27
Librarian	40
Accountant	3
Admin. assistant	5
Director/head of computing	3
Computing officer	5
Total (2 missing cases)	275

When asked about possible disadvantages to them personally, 56% did not feel that appraisal was too time consuming. A similar proportion (51%) did not feel that appraisal concentrated too much on past performance rather than future prospects. Some 73% disagreed with the suggestion that appraisal concentrated on their weaknesses rather than their strengths. Seventy one percent felt that appraisal had not given a misleading impression of their abilities. Seventy-three percent stated that their morale had not deteriorated as a result of their appraisal interview.

Respondents were questioned about benefits afforded to the university as a whole. Around half felt that appraisal had not improved the efficiency with which their university is managed nor had it improved staff motivation and performance in general. On the issue of disadvantages to the university, around half of the sample believed that appraisal was both too time consuming and too costly. However, 58% did not feel that appraisal had created divisiveness between staff and management and 68% did not feel it had created divisiveness between staff. Fifty-five percent felt that staff morale had not been adversely affected by the introduction of appraisal.

As in the pre-appraisal survey (Haslam *et al.* 1992), 60% felt that the appraisal record should play a part in promotion decisions and merit pay awards. Sixty-seven percent believed that appraisal should be taken into account in decisions on staff development policy across the university. Some 88% believed that appraisal should be used in the development and support of individuals and 78% thought it should play a part in the monitoring of individual performance.

When asked if they thought that the introduction of appraisal would enhance the public's image of universities and their staff, two thirds of the sample thought that it would not. Around half of the sample agreed that universities had not been firm enough in dealing with unacceptable levels of staff performance but a similar proportion disagreed with the suggestion that universities relied too heavily on self-discipline in their management of staff. Some 70% disagreed with the proposition that universities should play a larger role in determining the research activities of individual academics.

So staff did not find the procedure very useful in clarifying expectations or in formulating their own aims and objectives. Over half felt that appraisal had not improved their own motivation or performance, but, they did not feel that their morale had deteriorated as a result of appraisal implementation.

Interviews with staff and senior management

A sample of the respondents from the postal survey and non-respondents were interviewed to explore, in more detail, the responses to the actual implementation of appraisal. Table 6 gives the breakdown of the interview sample by faculty for each university.

The senior managers of the four universities including Vice Chancellors, Pro-Vice Chancellors and Registrars were also interviewed, along with some lay members of council and the local AUT representatives.

Table 6. The post-appraisal interview sample breakdown by faculty

Faculty	Uni. A	Uni. B	Uni. C	Uni D
Academic related		6	9	7
Arts and Humanities		9	19	8
Engineering	2	—	—	7
Science		12	4	10
Social Science		13	8	8
Total	2	40	40	40

Link with promotion and merit pay awards

Many staff and senior managers referred to the need for ‘Carrots and Sticks’ – rewards for good performance to motivate individuals and sanctions against repeated poor performance. As regards carrots, many staff asked what was the point of going through an appraisal interview year after year if there were no tangible inducements for good performance. Some commented that appraisal needs to be given ‘some teeth’ if the aim is to improve individual and departmental performance.

None of the appraisal schemes in the four institutions was linked to disciplinary procedures, so that there were no overt ‘sticks.’ However, some senior managers and staff expressed the view that there ought to be ‘negative carrots’ such as withholding annual increments, in exceptional circumstances. Senior managers acknowledged that appraisal might, in the future, be linked to merit pay awards such as the discretionary 1%.

In two of the institutions staff could use the agreed summary from their appraisal interview as part of the material they submitted to a promotions board. This was a recent development in one of the institutions (and one that coincided with the fieldwork interviews) which caused some disquiet in the departments because initially the university had stated that there would be no such link. Senior managers believed that such a link was crucial:

it must come that way in the end otherwise it just gives a management information system about people. It doesn't help the person. [linking appraisal to promotion] gives people something to aim for.

AUT representatives felt it preferable to develop an official link between agreed summaries and promotion rather than an unofficial link where Heads of Departments could quote from the appraisal documents without revealing their sources. However they noted that some staff had contacted them in alarm with comments such as:

good heavens, if I'd realised when I was appraised that I was going to have to come back to my appraiser and look through and find out what might be suitable for a promotion application then the whole interview might well have gone differently.

Hence, the counter argument to giving appraisal ‘some teeth’ is that it may militate against honesty in the self appraisal element of the process. If an

individual's promotion or merit pay award hangs to some extent on their appraisal interview they may well be inclined to paint 'a rosy picture' or be less likely to openly discuss any difficulties they are experiencing. This issue of 'honesty versus the information being used against you in evidence' is one which was well recognised by the AUT in the initial discussions of appraisal within universities. As one AUT representative put it:

. . . if we're talking about staff development then people do need to discuss their weaknesses and if you have a Head of Department who has to comment on your promotion application and who has a heap of forms which tell of your weaknesses over the years then malevolent Heads of Departments could make use of this.

Another of the case study institutions, which originally had this link with promotion, subsequently decided to drop the arrangement of using agreed summaries in the promotion procedures. This university had abandoned the arrangement because it was felt that staff review and appraisal were quite different exercises (for the reasons discussed above) and also because senior managers and Heads of Department had actually found the comments in the agreed summaries so bland as to be effectively useless.

Recognising teaching and administrative duties

Related to the link with promotion is the issue of acknowledging the importance of teaching. There was the suggestion that appraisal might have a crucial role to play in redressing the imbalance between the importance placed on research as opposed to teaching and administration. While promotions boards consider an individual's research output, teaching and administrative duties, respondents widely accepted that 'publications equals promotion.' Indeed some staff stated that had they been more aware of this earlier in their academic careers they might have been less willing to become so heavily involved with course administration and teaching.

Appraisal may offer a mechanism for recognising the teaching and administrative contributions of staff in a department. It was generally felt that individuals who have very impressive research outputs and/or those who have made a major contribution to a discipline have usually done so with the co-operation of their departmental colleagues who, because of the individual's commitment to research, have had to take on additional teaching or administrative duties.

Senior managers believed that 'teaching has been rather overshadowed by the research selectivity exercises' but that 'the pendulum is swinging back.' They felt that teaching is now being taken more seriously and that the 'buzz' words 'accountability' and 'efficiency' are now being replaced by 'quality' which they felt specifically relates to 'teaching quality.'

Link with departmental and university planning

Many appraisers and senior managers believed that appraisal should offer a way of reconciling the plans of individual members of staff with the overall plan for the department. In some instances this may even manifest itself in terms of the Head of

Department directing research activities as well as teaching and administrative duties. Where an individual member of staff had been pursuing a line of research which had proved not to be fruitful, financially or otherwise, the Head of Department might encourage him or her to develop alternative areas of research.

Staff often felt that they had been 'pigeon holed' in terms of their departmental duties. Many would prefer a more flexible approach to departmental management and suggested that an individual's teaching and administration responsibilities could be adjusted each year depending on their research commitments. This view was put forward by both relatively junior and senior members of staff. A number of young lecturers felt they were unable to pursue their research interests because they had found it difficult to fend off requests from the more senior colleagues aiming to 'off load' some of their teaching and administrative duties. Similarly, some senior lecturers stated that they would welcome the opportunity to be more active in research, often quite late in their career. Senior managers also believed that job rotation may be a potential motivator for some individuals within a department.

On the wider issue of university planning, some senior managers felt that universities in general were 'being pushed into a more bureaucratic mould' and that staff appraisal may 'be a safety valve for innovation.' A senior manager warned of the potential dangers of pushing such an approach too far:

. . . one can get a system which is beautifully structured, perfectly effective, perfectly efficient, it just doesn't do any decent teaching or research.

One point which many senior managers stressed was that in universities there are lines of communication, traditionally termed as collegiality. They emphasised the importance of recognising that:

some quite junior members of staff may have seminal ideas which are a good deal better than those of his or her seniors . . . you must not stifle that . . . you've got to have the line of communication in the lower limbs which somehow bypasses the structure . . . appraisal certainly won't make this worse and it might just make it better.

Overall impressions of staff and senior managers

Many staff commented that while they were initially sceptical about the appraisal procedure, they had actually found it was personally beneficial. Some initial scepticism stemmed from the fact that the procedure was imposed as a condition of a salary settlement. As regards the nature of the process, self appraisal was found to be the most useful and revealing part of the procedure by the vast majority of staff. Indeed it had made many of them realise the excessive amounts of work they were undertaking. Some became aware that the goals they routinely set themselves were often unrealistic, as one lecturer commented:

In actual fact I think we feel we're comparatively overworked. By any standards, even within this university, within Britain, within the world, we're overworked.

In recent years staff in academic and academic related departments have responded to the increased demands made upon them by working harder and longer

and taking more work home. Some remarked that through the appraisal process they had come to understand why they had, on occasion, been unable to achieve their goals. In terms of the wider organizational effects of appraisal some staff saw potential for improved performance but most were of the opinion that appraisal had limited use.

Discussion

There was little evidence to suggest that staff found appraisal very useful. Indeed, many believed that the exercise was time consuming and costly for universities with little tangible benefit. Some staff and senior managers felt that the procedure would be improved by linking appraisal to promotion procedures and merit pay awards. The hope was expressed that appraisal may afford a more equitable means of recognising and rewarding staff who have made significant teaching or administrative contributions to a department. Linking appraisal with promotion obviously gives it a more judgmental emphasis and may discourage staff from feeling able to fully discuss any difficulties they are experiencing in case this jeopardizes their career progression. Since many staff endorse a link between appraisal and promotion one assumes that they are prepared to accept this.

This then begs the question of whether using an agreed summary from the appraisal interview is the best method of linking the two procedures. The university which has discontinued the use of agreed summaries in promotion procedures did so because it was felt that appraisal and staff review are quite separate activities but also because comments in agreed summaries tended to be fairly insipid and of limited use. There may be a case for replacing the agreed summary with a confidential report made by the appraiser which could be used in considering individuals for promotion.

An obvious use of appraisal is in the future planning of departments and universities, but there is little indication that appraisal is presently being employed in this way. The use of appraisal in the task of human resource management could engender a more flexible and consensual approach to the management of departments. Some staff felt they had been 'pigeon holed' with regard to their departmental duties. The departmental plans and the implications of the appraisal interviews could be openly discussed in departmental staff meetings so that collective decisions and democratic negotiation of duties can be achieved. Heads of Department and senior managers believed that appraisal has the potential to facilitate communication within the university and to assist in reconciling departmental plans with the needs of individuals.

A valuable facet of the appraisal exercise for most staff was the self appraisal procedure. Some staff became more aware of the often significant administrative element of their role in the department and how this had impeded their career advancement. Given the emphasis placed on publications many staff believed they had blundered in their academic careers by being too prepared to shoulder heavy administrative loads. Depending on the way it is conducted, appraisal may serve to

mitigate this tension by recognising and rewarding individuals for their administrative contributions, or to exacerbate it by further emphasising research to the detriment of administrative tasks.

While many staff found the self appraisal aspect of the process personally beneficial, they did not feel that their appraisal interview had improved their motivation or efficiency. The most prevalent view was that appraisal is a relatively low key and under-resourced initiative and as such was seen as a rather ineffectual means of improving performance in universities.

This result should not be entirely unexpected for several reasons, not least because appraisal is not a new phenomenon in universities but more a formalization of a process which already existed. The implementation of systematic staff appraisal is still at an inaugural stage and the appraisal schemes themselves are under review and being further developed. It is also important to place the response to appraisal in the proper political and economic context. In a very real sense, staff appraisal in universities has been sidelined by the plethora of changes taking place in higher education such as bidding, research selectivity exercises and financial devolution to departments. These developments appear to have had a much greater impact on cost effectiveness and human resource management in universities than has appraisal and have also consumed people's attention to a much greater degree.

There appears to be widespread ambiguity surrounding the intentions of performance appraisal in universities, a point which was well recognised by senior managers in the pre-appraisal phase of this research (Haslam *et al.* 1992). Staff appraisal schemes in universities are what might be termed a hybrid model of appraisal, neither a management tool nor a wholly developmental model. If staff appraisal in universities is concerned with performance assessment, then it ought to be linked to promotion, merit pay awards and disciplinary procedures. While appraisal schemes have tended to avoid links with promotion or pay, as recommended by many writers on performance appraisal (e.g. Meyer *et al.* 1965), 60% of staff in both the pre- and post-appraisal surveys expressed the view that appraisal should be linked to promotion and merit pay awards. Similarly some senior managers would prefer appraisal schemes to be backed up by rewards for good performance and sanctions against poor performance.

If, on the other hand, staff appraisal in universities is primarily concerned with staff development and training, then it should be overtly stated (as is the case in a few universities) where it is referred to as 'staff development review.' To be effective it needs to be backed up with sufficient resources to meet the training needs identified by the process and to counter the scepticism which some staff have relating to the value of further training. Moreover, there needs to be a mechanism by which issues unearthed in the appraisal interviews are followed up and training needs met. This operates most effectively where the appraisal documents comprise a separate sheet listing training needs which is then sent directly to the Staff Training and Development staff, rather than relying purely on a Head of Department report of training needs.

Introducing performance appraisal in universities might be seen as a means of increasing the overall effectiveness and efficiency of these institutions. However, it

is perhaps worth pointing out here that while it is often assumed that staff appraisal affects performance, empirical support for this assumption is very limited (Nathan *et al.* 1991). So it is perhaps not surprising that respondents felt that the introduction of appraisal has had minimal impact on staff motivation and performance.

To be of real consequence, appraisal should be used in the future planning of departments as well as the wider organization. Appraisal, could be an integral part of university management. Indeed, one of the functions of appraisal, rather than it being purely a measure of individual performance, is to communicate organizational norms or culture, or at least, to reinforce this process (Townley 1989). Given the largely developmental ethos of most appraisal schemes in universities there are definite limits to the possibility of using appraisal in this way. But there is still scope for developing the process of reconciling the needs of the individual with the plans of the wider organization. Such a role for performance appraisal might have special significance in light of the dramatic changes in UK universities which depend on a transformation of the traditional collegial culture.

From the present research it is clear that virtually all universities have responded to the need to develop systematic staff appraisal schemes. But so far, at least, the appraisal process seems largely decoupled from the mainstream activities of universities.

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Note

¹Copies of the research instruments can be obtained by request to the first author.

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